SECTION 1: OBSERVATION FIELD DECLARATION

Phenomenon: the United Kingdom's decision to leave the European Union ("Brexit") and its consequences from the 2016 referendum through to 2026, including campaign, negotiation, withdrawal, trade reconfiguration, and downstream economic, institutional, and cultural effects.[1][2]

Temporal frame: June 2016 referendum through early 2026, covering the pre-withdrawal period, formal exit (2020), implementation of the Trade and Cooperation Agreement (TCA), the Northern Ireland Protocol and its revision through the Windsor Framework, and subsequent economic and political developments.[3][4][5]

Geographic scope: the United Kingdom as a whole, with special focus on:

- UK–EU relations (trade, regulation, migration).[6][7]
- Northern Ireland's differentiated status via the Protocol/Windsor Framework.[4][5][3]
- Scotland's constitutional politics and independence polling.[8][9]
- The UK's position in the wider international system (comparative GDP, trade performance).[10][2][1]

Why the phenomenon produces interpretive divergence:

- It contains **high-salience distributional effects** (winners/losers across classes, sectors, and regions), which naturally invite different causal attributions (elite betrayal vs popular sovereignty vs global capitalism).[2][1]
- Many signals are multi-valent: the same GDP or trade figure can be read as cost of "taking back control", as proof of sabotage, or as a necessary adjustment cost for long-term political autonomy.[1][10][2]
- The process itself is legally complex (Article 50, TCA, Protocol, Windsor Framework) and temporally stretched, allowing different actors to select different time-slices as decisive evidence.[5][3][4]

- Cultural and identity dimensions (national identity, “control”, attitudes to immigration, perceptions of elites) create divergent moral narratives that structure how economic and institutional facts are processed.[11][12][13]

Major interpretive communities:

- Sovereigntist/national-democratic actors (many Leave campaigners, some Conservative and Reform UK politicians, parts of the tabloid and partisan media, some US and global populist commentators).
- Economic-integration/institutionalist actors (many economists, civil servants, business organisations, EU institutions, centrist/liberal parties, much international media).[14][10][2][1]
- Class/distributional and critical-political actors (trade unionists, left and some right populists, critical political economists, some academic and journalistic communities concerned with inequality and deindustrialisation).[2][1]

These communities serve as anchor traditions for the three interpretive grammars developed below.

SECTION 2: SIGNAL SET

Core signals (shared empirical inputs)

1. **Referendum result (52–48 Leave)**
    - Description: UK-wide vote to leave the EU, with 51.9% Leave and 48.1% Remain, displaying marked regional, age, and class splits.
    - Source: UK Electoral Commission official referendum results.
    - Type: Quantitative / institutional.
2. **GDP trajectory pre- and post-Brexit**
    - Description: After tracking peers pre-2016, UK GDP per head grows more slowly than comparable economies from 2016 onwards; estimates suggest GDP per capita in 2025 is roughly 6–8% lower than a no-Brexit counterfactual.[14][1][2]
    - Source: NBER paper and “UK in a Changing Europe” analysis, drawing on ONS and comparative macro data.[14][1][2]
    - Type: Quantitative / economic.

3. **Investment, productivity, and employment effects**
    - Description: By 2025 investment estimated 12–18% lower, productivity and employment around 3–4% lower than they would have been without Brexit.[1][2]
    - Source: NBER and related analyses.[2][1]
    - Type: Quantitative / economic.
4. **Trade volumes with EU and non-EU partners**
    - Description: Headline trade remains relatively robust; goods exports to the EU have not underperformed exports to the rest of the world, and services exports to both EU and non-EU have grown since leaving the single market.[15][10][6]
    - Source: UK in a Changing Europe, Centre for European Reform, UK government "UK Trade in Numbers".[15][10][6]
    - Type: Quantitative / economic.
5. **Post-Brexit trade frictions and non-tariff barriers**
    - Description: The TCA keeps tariffs at zero but introduces significant non-tariff barriers (customs paperwork, rules of origin, regulatory checks), especially in goods trade with the EU.[10][15]
    - Source: UK in a Changing Europe, CER analysis.[15][10]
    - Type: Institutional / economic.
6. **Net migration levels and composition**
    - Description: Net migration peaks around 944,000 in the year ending March 2023, then falls sharply to about 204,000 by mid-2025, returning to roughly 2010s levels; net migration of EU nationals turns negative, while non-EU work and study migration dominates.[16][7][11]
    - Source: ONS provisional migration estimates; Migration Observatory analysis.[7][16][11]
    - Type: Quantitative / demographic.
7. **Emigration of British citizens and EU nationals**
    - Description: Net emigration of British citizens (around 109,000 in year ending June 2025) and persistent negative net migration of EU nationals post-referendum.[11][7]

- Source: ONS, Migration Observatory.[7][11]
- Type: Quantitative / behavioural.

8. **Northern Ireland Protocol and Windsor Framework**
    - Description: Protocol places Northern Ireland in a special regime to avoid a hard border on the island while protecting EU single market; Windsor Framework (2023) amends it, creating "green" and "red" lanes, expanding UK regulatory control in some areas and introducing mechanisms like the "Stormont Brake".[17][3][4][5]
    - Source: UK government statements; NI Assembly explainer; Windsor Framework documentation.[17][3][4][5]
    - Type: Institutional.
9. **Scottish independence polling**
    - Description: Since the 2014 referendum (55–45 No), support for independence oscillates but remains close to parity, briefly reaching 53% "Yes" around 2020–2022 and at 46% "Yes" vs 54% "No" in March 2025.[18][9][8]
    - Source: YouGov tracker and Statista summary.[9][8][18]
    - Type: Quantitative / cultural-political.
10. **Trust in government and political institutions**
    - Description: British Social Attitudes and other surveys show trust in government at record lows; nearly 45% say they "almost never" trust governments to prioritise national interest over party interest; Leave voters who think Brexit hasn't strengthened law-making are particularly distrustful.[12][13]
    - Source: NatCen, BSA, Edelman Trust Barometer summaries.[13][12]
    - Type: Quantitative / cultural-political.
11. **Trust and confidence among EU citizens in the UK**
    - Description: Post-Brexit surveys of EU citizens in the UK reveal significant lack of trust and confidence in UK public bodies, citing Brexit-related negativity, fear of discrimination, and concerns about rights enforcement.[19]
    - Source: Independent Monitoring Authority (IMA) survey.[19]
    - Type: Cultural / institutional.

12. **Sectoral performance: services vs manufacturing**
    - Description: UK services exports have grown strongly post-Brexit, including to the EU; goods exports show more strain but have not dramatically underperformed non-EU goods exports.[10][15]
    - Source: CER, UK in a Changing Europe.[15][10]
    - Type: Quantitative / economic.
13. **Regulatory divergence and control**
    - Description: UK has gained formal capacity to diverge from EU rules, including setting its own trade policy and adjusting regulation in areas like state aid, tax, and some product standards, though actual divergence remains partial and politically constrained.[4][5][17]
    - Source: Windsor Framework texts, UK government statements, NI Assembly summary.[5][17][4]
    - Type: Institutional.
14. **Perceived effectiveness of "taking back control"**
    - Description: Among 2016 Leave voters, the share who believe Brexit has strengthened Britain's ability to make its own laws has fallen sharply since 2019; those disappointed in Brexit's performance report particularly low trust in government.[12]
    - Source: NatCen analysis of British Social Attitudes.[12]
    - Type: Cultural / attitudinal.
15. **Constitutional and territorial strain**
    - Description: Brexit has intensified debate over the UK's territorial constitution (Northern Ireland status, Scottish independence demand, EU citizens' rights framework), but has not yet produced a major territorial rupture (Scotland remains in the UK; NI remains within the Union with a special status).[3][9][17]
    - Source: Polling, constitutional arrangements, Windsor Framework.[9][17][3]
    - Type: Institutional / cultural.

Counter-signals (complicating or inversion-prone datasets)

1. **Resilience and growth in services exports**

- Description: Despite predictions of severe damage, services exports to both EU and non-EU markets have grown robustly after Brexit.[10][15]
- Complication: Softens interpretations of Brexit as unambiguously economically catastrophic, and challenges claims that Britain has become globally irrelevant.[15][10]

2. **Robust headline trade with the EU**
   - Description: Goods exports to the EU have not performed worse than exports to the rest of the world despite added frictions.[6][10]
   - Complication: Undercuts expectations that Brexit would necessarily reorient trade dramatically away from the EU or lead to a collapse in EU trade.[6][10]
3. **Return of net migration to 2010s levels by 2025**
   - Description: After huge post-pandemic peaks, net migration falls back to roughly pre-Brexit norms by mid-2025, though composition shifts toward non-EU.[11][7]
   - Complication: Challenges both "Brexit has ended mass migration" and "Brexit has unleashed permanently uncontrolled migration" narratives, and complicates claims that immigration was structurally resolved by Brexit.[7][11]
4. **Stability of Scottish unionist majority (so far)**
   - Description: Despite spikes of pro-independence sentiment, "No" remains slightly ahead by 2025.[8][9]
   - Complication: Contradicts claims that Brexit has already made the break-up of the UK inevitable.[8][9]
5. **Partial institutional adaptation and problem-solving**
   - Description: The Windsor Framework modifies the Protocol to reduce trade frictions in the Irish Sea and enhance NI's constitutional position while still protecting the EU single market.[17][3][4][5]
   - Complication: Complicates narratives that depict Brexit-related institutional issues as either insoluble or fully solved; the evidence suggests iterative, technocratic adaptation instead.[3][4][5][17]

These core signals and counter-signals form the constant empirical "beam" that will be refracted by different interpretive grammars.

SECTION 3: GRAMMAR SPECIFICATIONS

Grammar 1: Sovereign-Democratic Restoration

- **Grammar name:** Sovereign-Democratic Restoration
- **Primary analytical variable:** Popular sovereignty and national democratic self-determination.
- **Signal selection rules:**
  - Privileges signals that speak to legal authority, border control, and policy autonomy (referendum result; formal regaining of trade and regulatory competences; Windsor Framework's affirmation of UK constitutional authority).[4][5][17]
  - Admits economic data selectively when it can be framed as "short-term cost for long-term freedom" or as effects of sabotage, global headwinds, or poor domestic management rather than Brexit per se.[1][2]
  - Gives particular weight to attitudinal data on "control" and perceptions of law-making power (even if negative, because they register an unfinished project).[12]
- **Weighting priority:**
  - Constitutional/legal control and democratic consent.
  - Territorial integrity and border sovereignty.
  - Long-run economic potential under self-determined rules; short-run economic indicators are demoted or reframed.
- **Causal chain type:** Moral–constitutional causal chain: loss or restoration of sovereignty is primary; economic and social outcomes are downstream of whether the polity can act as a self-governing nation.
- **Admissible closure:**
  - Brexit is fundamentally justified as the rectification of a democratic and constitutional deficit; any current disappointments are due to incomplete implementation, managerial errors, or external obstruction.

    - The correct prescription is to “finish the job”: deepen regulatory divergence where it serves national interest, renegotiate where necessary, and orient institutions around the referendum mandate.
- **Excluded signals:**
    - Structural economic modelling that attributes most growth under-performance directly to Brexit is downplayed or re-coded as pessimistic or politically motivated.[14][2][1]
    - EU citizens’ distrust and some business-confidence indicators are minimised as transient grievances or communication failures.[13][19]
- **Characteristic vocabulary:**
    - “Taking back control”, “the will of the people”, “sovereign parliament”, “unelected Brussels bureaucrats”, “making our own laws”, “freedom to strike our own trade deals”, “short-term pain, long-term gain”, “finishing Brexit”, “global Britain”.
- **Source tradition:**
    - British parliamentary sovereignty doctrine, Eurosceptic constitutionalism, populist democratic rhetoric, national-conservative thought, strands of post-imperial British exceptionalism.

Grammar 2: Economic-Institutional Integration

- **Grammar name:** Economic-Institutional Integration
- **Primary analytical variable:** Degree of integration with large-scale economic and legal regimes (single market, customs union, shared regulatory frameworks).
- **Signal selection rules:**
    - Admits and foregrounds macroeconomic data (GDP, productivity, trade, investment), sectoral performance, and business environment indicators.[2][14][1][10][15]
    - Prioritises institutional arrangements that lower or raise transaction costs (TCA design, Protocol/Windsor Framework, regulatory divergence).[5][17][3][4]
    - Uses comparative data (UK vs peer economies) to infer integration effects.[14][1][2]
- **Weighting priority:**
    - GDP, productivity, investment trends relative to counterfactual.

    - Trade intensity and frictions with nearest major market (EU).
    - Institutional complexity and legal uncertainty as costs to business.
- **Causal chain type:** Systemic-causal and micro-economic: changes in trade and regulatory arrangements produce changes in costs, incentives, and hence macro outcomes.
- **Admissible closure:**
    - Brexit is economically damaging relative to continued EU membership; the evidence points to a persistent GDP and productivity cost.
    - The normative prescription is to minimise economic damage by aligning more closely with EU rules or rebuilding integration through sectoral accords; in strong forms, the closure may be "rejoin" or "quasi-membership".
- **Excluded signals:**
    - Moral claims about sovereignty that cannot be translated into measurable welfare gains.
    - Identity-symbolic interpretations that treat political "control" as a benefit irrespective of economic outcome.
- **Characteristic vocabulary:**
    - "Frictions", "non-tariff barriers", "single market access", "trade intensity", "lost growth", "negative supply shock", "uncertainty shock", "gravity model", "regulatory alignment vs divergence", "institutional efficiency".
- **Source tradition:**
    - Neoclassical trade theory, new economic geography, political economy of European integration, technocratic policy analysis, international business and FDI literature.

Grammar 3: Class-Distributional and Regime-Critical

- **Grammar name:** Class-Distributional Regime Critique
- **Primary analytical variable:** Class structure and distributional regime (who gains and who loses, and how this is embedded in a broader neoliberal or oligarchic order).
- **Signal selection rules:**

  - Admits data that reveal differentiated impacts by class, sector, and region (manufacturing vs services, deindustrialised regions vs metropolitan hubs, migrants vs natives, core vs periphery).[1][10][2][15]
  - Treats political events (referendum, negotiations) as expressions of class conflict and crises of legitimacy; institutional trust metrics and migration patterns are read through this lens.[13][11][12]
  - Seeks evidence of capital mobility vs labour precarity, and of the restructuring of state power.
- **Weighting priority:**
  - Distribution of economic costs and benefits across social classes and territories.
  - Changes in labour bargaining power, job quality, and social protections.
  - Shifts in political legitimacy and trust in elites.
- **Causal chain type:** Critical-structural: Brexit is both symptom and instrument of a broader crisis of neoliberal governance and class compromise; causal chains track how capital and state actors manage this crisis.
- **Admissible closure:**
  - Brexit is best understood as a crisis event within a longer trajectory of class and regime transformation; it redistributes costs largely onto labour and marginalised groups while preserving or reconfiguring elite power.
  - The normative implication is that the core problem is the regime (neoliberal, oligarchic), not membership status per se; both hard and soft Brexit paths can entrench inequality if regime structures are unchanged.
- **Excluded signals:**
  - "Sovereignty" framed at purely national scale without examining whose sovereignty (class, region, race).
  - Purely technocratic assessments of trade costs that bracket distributional conflict and power.
- **Characteristic vocabulary:**
  - "Left-behind", "austerity", "precarity", "neoliberal settlement", "regime crisis", "authoritarian populism", "symbolic politics vs material inequalities", "spatial inequality", "labour vs capital".

- **Source tradition:**
    - Marxian and neo-Marxian political economy, critical sociology, regime-theory and Varieties of Capitalism literature, critical Brexit studies, some strands of populist left and right critique.

These three grammars maximise interpretive divergence by grounding explanation in sovereignty, integration efficiency, and class regime respectively.

SECTION 4: SIGNAL PROCESSING

4.1 Sovereign-Democratic Restoration

From within the Sovereign-Democratic Restoration grammar, the primary variable is the **location of supreme decision-making authority**. The central question is not "what is GDP today?" but "who decides the rules under which GDP rises or falls?" Economic and institutional signals are filtered through the overriding imperative of restoring popular and parliamentary sovereignty.

The 2016 referendum result is the foundational signal. It is read as a clear democratic instruction to leave the EU: 52% of voters—across millions of citizens—chose to "take back control", despite a massive alignment of political, economic, and cultural elites in favour of Remain. This signal is weighted above all others: it is the manifestation of the people's will, not a contingent poll. The grammar therefore treats subsequent institutional and economic developments as either faithful execution or betrayal of that instruction.[12][1]

GDP and productivity signals are admitted but demoted. Yes, economic studies estimate that by 2025 UK GDP per capita may be 6–8% lower than it would have been under continued EU membership. But three moves reprocess this:[2][14][1]

- First, these are **counterfactual estimates**, not concrete events; they are subject to modelling assumptions, and the models are often produced by institutions predisposed to favour integration.[14][1][2]
- Second, the period 2016–2025 overlaps with other shocks (global slowdown, pandemic, war-linked energy prices) that any honest comparison must disentangle.[1][2]
- Third, sovereignty grammarians argue that democracies sometimes choose goals that are not immediately growth-maximising, such as rearmament, environmental protection, or national security; reclaiming the ability to set one's own rules is a similar category.

Trade data are processed similarly. Headline trade performance has been more resilient than many predicted; goods exports to the EU have not fared worse than those to non-EU markets, and services exports have grown robustly. These signals are welcomed as evidence that a sovereign UK can sustain a strong trade relationship with Europe while also pursuing global opportunities. Non-tariff barriers under the TCA are framed as manageable costs of being an independent trading nation rather than a sub-unit of a larger bloc. The grammar emphasises that zero tariffs have been maintained and that administrative hurdles can be streamlined over time while preserving the essential gain: the power to sign and revise trade agreements autonomously.[6][10][15]

The Northern Ireland Protocol and Windsor Framework are read primarily through a constitutional lens. The Protocol is acknowledged as an imperfect but necessary arrangement to respect prior commitments (Good Friday Agreement) while honouring the referendum. Criticism focuses on how far the Protocol initially compromised the unity of the UK internal market by creating an internal trade border; this is treated as a partial derogation of sovereignty. The Windsor Framework's green/red lane system and the Stormont Brake are then interpreted as steps toward **reasserting UK constitutional control**: easing checks, affirming NI's place in the Union, and giving UK institutions mechanisms to resist unwanted EU rule changes. This grammar thus weights the Framework's language about replacing "swathes of EU law with UK law" and putting "the people of Northern Ireland in charge" more heavily than the continued practical entanglement with EU regulation.[17][3][4][5]

Migration and demographic signals are central because they speak directly to borders and control. The surge in net migration to nearly a million in the year ending March 2023 is acknowledged but reframed as a transitional anomaly driven by post-pandemic recovery and specific policy choices rather than an inherent feature of Brexit. The subsequent sharp fall to around 204,000 by mid-2025, close to 2010s levels, is treated as proof that the UK now has the tools to adjust migration flows according to democratically mandated preferences. The composition shift—negative net migration of EU nationals and positive non-EU flows dominated by work and study routes—is cast as a sovereign choice to design a skills-based system responsive to national needs. If British citizens and EU nationals are leaving at higher net rates, this is regrettable but framed as an aspect of free choice in a global labour market, not a violation of sovereignty.[16][11][7]

Trust in government and institutions appears as a diagnostic, not a core evaluative variable. Rising distrust, including among Leave voters who feel Brexit has not strengthened Britain's law-making capacity, is read as evidence of **incomplete or mishandled implementation** rather than indictment of Brexit itself. The grammar distinguishes between "Brexit as democratic mandate" and "Brexit as executed by particular governments"; declining trust indicates that elected elites have not fully delivered on the democratic promise of control, or have entangled the UK in excessively cautious,

technocratic interpretations of Brexit. EU citizens' distrust in UK public bodies is similarly read as a sign that institutions have struggled to communicate and operationalise citizens' rights, not as a reason to reverse sovereignty.[19][13][12]

Scottish independence polling and territorial strain are processed through a unity-sovereignty axis. The oscillation around 45–55 "Yes/No" and the current slight majority for No are taken as evidence that the UK remains a viable sovereign union, despite ongoing debate. The grammar stresses that Scotland voted in 2014 to remain in the UK, and that this decision is part of the same democratic continuum in which the UK as a whole voted to leave the EU. Demands for a second referendum are framed as legitimate but not inevitable; the key is that any decision is taken within the UK's sovereign constitutional framework, not via external pressure. Territorial complexities in Northern Ireland are acknowledged as real but manageable within an overarching sovereign settlement that maintains control of borders and law while respecting local consent mechanisms.[9][8][3][4][17]

Sectoral performance, particularly the relative strength of services exports, is marshalled as support for a **"Global Britain"** narrative. Services-heavy economies are less constrained by goods-focused trade frictions, and the UK's continued success in services trade with EU and non-EU markets is treated as evidence that a sovereign UK can thrive in high-value sectors outside the EU. Manufacturing strains are seen partly as legacies of pre-Brexit industrial decline and global competition; Brexit is reframed as an opportunity to tailor industrial policy, subsidies, and regulation to domestic priorities without EU state-aid constraints.[10][15][1]

Counter-signals that this grammar must grapple with include:

- The consistent macro evidence of a GDP and productivity gap relative to the no-Brexit counterfactual.[2][14][1]
- The fall in Leave voters' belief that Brexit has strengthened Britain's ability to make its own laws.[12]

The first is handled by emphasising the counterfactual nature of the estimates and attributing much of the observed under-performance to a combination of global shocks and domestic policy missteps (hesitation in deregulation, internal political turmoil), not to the foundational choice to exit. The second is accommodated by arguing that Brexit is a **process**, not a single event: if people do not yet feel more in control, it is because subsequent governments have, in effect, "soft-pedalled" Brexit, failing to use the full range of newly available freedoms or failing to communicate them.[13][1][2][12]

The closure: from within this grammar, Brexit remains a **democratically legitimate and necessary restoration of sovereign self-government**, partially frustrated and distorted by

hesitant or incompetent execution. Economic and institutional difficulties are interpreted as transitional and, where persistent, as reasons to deepen sovereign control, not reverse it. This is a closure produced by the grammar's prioritisation of democratic sovereignty over other variables, not an all-things-considered assessment of Brexit's total impact.

4.2 Economic-Institutional Integration

Within the Economic-Institutional Integration grammar, the primary question is: **what has changing the UK's integration status with the EU done to welfare, efficiency, and growth?** Sovereignty is recognised but treated as a constraint or parameter; the focus is on measurable economic outcomes and the institutional channels that produce them.

The referendum result is a starting condition rather than a normative anchor. It establishes that the UK chose a path away from the single market and customs union into a looser Trade and Cooperation Agreement with the EU. From an integration perspective, this move predictably increases trade costs with the UK's largest and geographically closest trading partner. The grammar uses gravity-model intuition: trade intensity falls with distance and rises with institutional integration; therefore, weakening integration with the EU should reduce trade and investment relative to a counterfactual where the UK remains integrated.

The GDP and productivity signals are central. Studies estimate that by 2025, UK GDP per capita is about 6–8% lower than it would have been without Brexit, with investment down 12–18% and productivity and employment also lower than the counterfactual. Within this grammar, such findings are unsurprising and carry high evidential weight: they reflect exactly the kinds of long-term, cumulative costs expected when a medium-sized economy erects new barriers to its main export market. The UK's slower GDP per head growth compared to comparable economies after 2016 is interpreted as empirical confirmation of the integration hypothesis.[14][1][2]

Trade data refine this picture. Headline goods exports to the EU have not dramatically underperformed exports to non-EU countries, and services exports have grown robustly to both EU and non-EU markets. These are treated as **counter-signals** that complicate simple collapse narratives but not as refutations of cost. The grammar emphasises that:[6][15][10]

- Without Brexit, trade might have been higher still; comparisons are against counterfactual trends, not absolute stagnation.[15][10][1]

- Firms have absorbed new non-tariff barriers by restructuring supply chains, reducing margins, and in some cases exiting smaller or more complex EU markets.[10][15]
- The fact that EU and non-EU exports track each other suggests that Brexit has delivered a broadly negative trade shock, with EU-specific frictions offset by global conditions, not that Brexit is neutral.[6][10]

The TCA's non-tariff barriers are foregrounded. The requirement to comply with rules of origin, additional customs paperwork, regulatory checks, and duplicated certifications all raise the fixed and variable costs of exporting, especially for SMEs. From this perspective, the choice to leave the single market and customs union is akin to imposing a structural, permanent tax on trade, even if headline tariff rates remain zero. Institutional complexity—such as diverging standards and conformity assessment regimes—is treated as a drag on competitiveness and productivity growth.[15][10]

The Northern Ireland Protocol and Windsor Framework are interpreted as institutional responses to a self-inflicted constraint: the UK's political decision to leave the EU single market while preserving an open border on the island of Ireland. From an integration grammar, the Protocol is an attempt to finesse an intractable geometry: Northern Ireland must, in effect, remain partly inside the EU's regulatory orbit to avoid a hard land border, producing friction within the UK internal market. The Windsor Framework's green/red lanes and Stormont Brake are viewed as incremental improvements that reduce some frictions but at the cost of continued administrative complexity and legal uncertainty for businesses. Rather than a restoration of control, this is read as a patch on a sub-optimal institutional configuration compared to full single-market membership.[3][4][5][17]

Migration data are processed as part of the human-capital and labour-market dimensions of integration. The sharp spike in net migration around 2022–2023 followed by a drop to 204,000 in mid-2025 is less central than the structural shift: net migration of EU nationals turns negative while non-EU work and study migration surges. The grammar asks whether this reconfiguration enhances or reduces the UK's ability to attract the talent and labour it needs with minimal friction. Loss of automatic free movement with the EU is interpreted as a reduction in the UK's integration with its closest labour market, increasing recruitment costs, introducing visa-related hurdles, and reducing flexibility for firms.[11][7]

Emigration of British citizens and EU nationals is seen as a signal of reduced attractiveness or increased uncertainty, though the evidence is interpreted cautiously due to methodological changes. The key integration point is that elevated frictions on people's movement are likely to reduce dynamism in sectors reliant on cross-border mobility, such as universities, high-skilled services, and seasonal agriculture.[7][11]

Institutional trust data are processed as indirect indicators of regime performance. Declining trust in government, particularly among Leave voters who no longer believe Brexit has strengthened Britain's ability to make its own laws, suggests that the political promise of Brexit has not translated into perceived institutional effectiveness. From an integration perspective, this is partly because Brexit has consumed administrative bandwidth and produced complex, sometimes incoherent arrangements (e.g., NI Protocol) that citizens experience as dysfunction rather than empowerment. EU citizens' distrust in UK institutions is interpreted as a cost to integration: talented workers and their families may be less inclined to settle or invest their lives in the UK if they perceive legal and administrative insecurity.[19][4][17][3][13][12]

Sectoral performance amplifies the integration story. The relative resilience of services exports suggests that Britain's strengths in high-value services, many of which rely on intangible assets and digital delivery, have buffered some of the damage from reduced integration in goods. However, the grammar notes that services access to the EU single market has nonetheless been weakened (e.g., loss of passporting in financial services), and that observed resilience likely reflects sunk advantages and adaptation rather than an absence of cost. Manufacturing, by contrast, is more exposed to border frictions and rules-of-origin constraints; its under-performance relative to a no-Brexit scenario is read as a textbook effect of adding trade barriers with a key market.[1][10][15]

Counter-signals to this grammar include:

- Headline resilience of UK trade with the EU and strong growth in services exports.[10][6][15]
- The stability of the UK's territorial integrity—Scotland remains in the union, and the Windsor Framework has stabilised (if not solved) the NI issue.[9][17][3]

The grammar accommodates the first by stressing that integration analysis uses counterfactuals: resilience does not imply absence of loss; it suggests that firms absorbed shocks and that the UK's pre-existing strengths cushioned the blow. The second is acknowledged as reducing certain high-impact tail risks (e.g., immediate break-up), but it is not central: the main vector of evaluation remains economic. Territorial stability is treated as a political outcome whose economic value can be measured, but it does not overturn the core inference that reducing integration has been costly.[17][3][9][15][1][10]

The closure: from within this grammar, the evidence supports the conclusion that **Brexit has imposed a large and persistent economic and institutional cost** on the UK relative to continued EU integration, with modest compensating gains in policy flexibility that have not yet translated into measurable welfare improvements. The rational prescription is closer alignment or

reintegration to minimise continuing losses. This closure reflects the grammar's commitment to integration as the primary explanatory and evaluative axis.

4.3 Class-Distributional Regime Critique

The Class-Distributional Regime Critique grammar treats Brexit as a **crisis moment in a longer trajectory of neoliberal restructuring, austerity, and spatial inequality**. The key variable is not sovereignty or integration but the class and regional distribution of material and political power.

The 2016 referendum result is read as an expression of accumulated grievances among those "left behind" by decades of deindustrialisation, welfare retrenchment, and precarious work. The 52–48 split and its geography map onto existing fault lines: deindustrialised towns, coastal communities, and some traditional Labour regions vote Leave, while metropolitan, higher-educated areas vote Remain. The grammar sees this not as a spontaneous eruption of Euroscepticism but as a **venting of anger at a domestic class settlement** that used EU integration as one of its institutional pillars. The referendum thus becomes a diagnostic of regime crisis: a significant portion of the working and lower-middle classes no longer accept the promises of the existing order.

GDP and productivity data are processed not as abstract indicators but as totals that conceal distribution. An 8% GDP per capita shortfall relative to a no-Brexit scenario is important, but the grammar asks: **who bears this loss, and who can hedge against it?** The answer is asymmetric. Capital-rich actors and mobile professionals can diversify, relocate, or pass costs down; precarious workers in tradable manufacturing, small exporters, and public-sector employees in austerity-hit regions cannot. Lower investment and productivity growth intensify competitive pressures; firms respond with wage restraint, casualisation, and offshoring. Brexit thus deepens tendencies already present in the neoliberal regime.[2][14][1]

Trade and sectoral data reinforce this. Manufacturing is more exposed to new non-tariff barriers, rules of origin, and regulatory duplication; these burdens fall disproportionately on SMEs and on regions that still rely on goods production. Meanwhile, services—especially high-value, knowledge-intensive services concentrated in London and the South East—show resilience and growth. This divergence widens inter-regional and class inequalities: metropolitan professionals in services can better navigate and even profit from the new regime, while workers in "left-behind" regions face compounding disadvantages.[15][1][10]

The grammar emphasises that Brexit's formal economic "cost" is not simply a national burden; it is part of a distributional story in which loss is socialised downwards while opportunities are privatised

upwards. Even when headline trade numbers with the EU remain robust, firms may have adjusted by consolidating production, automating, or closing marginal plants, all of which have class and spatial consequences that GDP aggregates do not capture.[6][10][15]

Migration trends are also refracted through class. The pre-Brexit period saw high net migration, particularly from EU countries, into low-wage sectors like food processing, social care, and hospitality. The grammar does not accept simple anti-migrant narratives but notes that employers and political elites used free movement to sustain a **low-wage, flexible labour model**, while austerity eroded protections and public services. The post-Brexit shift to negative net migration of EU nationals and increased non-EU work/study flows indicates a re-engineering of this model rather than its abandonment. A skills-based system can still be deployed to undercut labour power and segment the workforce, especially if trade unions are weak and employment protections are not strengthened.[11][7]

The drop in net migration to 204,000 by mid-2025 is not, in itself, an egalitarian achievement. Without concomitant reforms in housing, wages, public investment, and social security, reductions in migration may not significantly improve conditions for the worst-off. Instead, the grammar looks for evidence that elites are using Brexit to reconfigure labour supply in ways that maintain control: high-skilled entrants welcomed; low-wage migrants still used strategically; domestic workers kept in precarity.[7][11]

Institutional trust data are crucial. Record-low trust in government and plummeting confidence among Leave voters who feel Brexit has not delivered more control are interpreted as evidence of **regime disillusionment**. Brexit was marketed as a way to “take control”, but key structural features—financialisation, low public investment, weak labour bargaining power, centralised state power—remain largely intact. From this perspective, Brexit appears as a **symbolic rupture** that has been channelled into a reconfiguration of the same underlying regime: some regulatory and trade arrangements change, but core class relations persist. EU citizens’ distrust in UK institutions, and fears of discrimination post-Brexit, are seen as part of a broader pattern in which migrant and minority groups experience the state as arbitrary and punitive.[19][13][12]

The Northern Ireland Protocol and Windsor Framework are interpreted as revealing the limits of sovereign rhetoric when confronted with structural constraints. The need to preserve an open Irish border for peace and trade, while exiting the EU, forces the UK into complex compromises—green and red lanes, partial retention of EU rules—that expose the **interdependence** created by decades of integration. From a class-distributional perspective, the crucial question is how these arrangements affect different communities in NI: large agrifood exporters, small retailers, unionist vs nationalist working-class populations. The grammar highlights that the burden of paperwork and uncertainty

often falls on smaller firms and workers, while larger corporations have the resources to manage compliance.[4][5][3][17]

Scottish independence polling and territorial tensions are read as manifestations of **multi-scalar regime crisis**: different parts of the UK seek ways to escape or renegotiate a settlement that has delivered austerity and inequality. That "No" still leads in 2025 indicates that the regime's territorial shell holds, but the persistent high level of "Yes" support shows ongoing discontent. The grammar asks how Brexit has been instrumentalised: some Scottish elites use it to re-frame independence as a route back into the EU and away from UK austerity; UK elites use Brexit to mobilise national identity against both EU and internal challengers. The result is a dynamic in which class issues are refracted through national and territorial frames, often obscuring underlying economic interests.[8][9]

Counter-signals include:

- The resilience and growth of services exports and the continued strong performance of some high-value sectors.[10][15]
- The return of net migration to 2010s levels, which might suggest that migration pressure is not structurally escalating.[11][7]

The grammar accommodates the first by stressing that service-sector resilience primarily benefits already advantaged classes and regions; it is, in fact, evidence of the regime's continuity rather than its transformation. The second is interpreted as showing that migration can be modulated, but without regime change, the basic pattern—migrant labour deployed within a low-protection, flexible labour market—persists.[7][11][15][10]

The closure: from inside this grammar, Brexit is best understood as a **symptom and partial instrument of an ongoing class and regime crisis**. It has redistributed costs mainly onto labour, smaller firms, and peripheral regions, while leaving core features of the neoliberal settlement intact; some elites even leverage Brexit to consolidate power. The appropriate analytic focus is not "in or out of the EU" but how political and economic institutions structure distribution of risk, security, and voice. This closure arises from a grammar that centres class and regime dynamics over constitutional or integrationist metrics.

SECTION 5: CLOSURE COMPARISON

The three grammars diverge most sharply on **what counts as the primary success or failure criterion**. The Sovereign-Democratic Restoration grammar treats the referendum result and

subsequent legal changes as decisive: Brexit is fundamentally about regaining the authority to decide. The Economic-Institutional Integration grammar centres GDP, productivity, and trade metrics, concluding that reduced integration has generated a persistent economic cost. The Class-Distributional grammar focuses on who gains and who loses, interpreting Brexit as a crisis episode within a longer trajectory of inequality and regime management.[5][3][4][17][14][1][2]

Several specific signals produce acute divergence:

- **GDP and productivity estimates** (e.g., 6–8% loss by 2025). Sovereignty grammarians demote these, reframe them as transitional, or treat them as model-dependent; integrationists treat them as primary evidence; class grammarians treat them as aggregate proxies concealing distribution.[14][1][2]
- **Northern Ireland Protocol/Windsor Framework.** Sovereignty grammar sees constitutional reclamation and union affirmation; integration grammar sees complex, second-best institutional fixes to a self-created constraint; class grammar sees distribution of compliance burdens and exposure of interdependence.[3][4][5][17]
- **Migration patterns.** Sovereignty grammar sees regained control and the ability to design a national system; integration grammar sees increased frictions on labour mobility; class grammar sees continuity and adjustment in a flexible labour regime that still disciplines workers.[11][7]

There is meaningful convergence in some areas. All grammars accept the referendum result, the existence of trade frictions, the special status of Northern Ireland, and the decline in trust in government; they differ in causal attribution and normative evaluation. All recognise that the Windsor Framework ameliorates some problems created by the original Protocol. Each acknowledges that Brexit has not yet precipitated territorial dissolution; Scotland remains in the UK and unionist support remains slightly ahead.[8][4][9][13][5][17][3][12]

What each grammar excludes that others see:

- The Sovereign-Democratic grammar **excludes or marginalises structural economic costs** and detailed class analysis, treating them as secondary to the democratic mandate.[1][2][14]
- The Economic-Institutional grammar **excludes sovereignty as an intrinsic good** and underweights identity and class symbolism, seeing them mainly as constraints or noise.[12]
- The Class-Distributional grammar **excludes nation-level sovereignty metrics** and treats technical trade integration largely as instruments of class power, thereby underplaying some genuine policy-autonomy and efficiency considerations.[15][10]

The pattern of divergence spans facts, causation, and prescription. Factual disagreement is often **about counterfactuals and salience** ("how big is the Brexit cost?" "how much control has actually increased?"), not about core descriptive events. Causal divergence arises because each grammar privileges different mechanisms—moral-constitutional, transactional-institutional, or structural-class. Prescriptions then flow almost mechanically: "finish Brexit" (Grammar 1), "reintegrate or align" (Grammar 2), "transform the regime beyond Brexit" (Grammar 3). The prismatic method makes visible that these prescriptions are not simply reactions to "the same facts" but outputs of distinct processing architectures.[17][3][2][14][1]

SECTION 6: COUNTER-SIGNAL ANALYSIS AND LEAKAGE

6.1 Sovereign-Democratic Restoration

Threatening counter-signals:

- **Persistent GDP and productivity shortfall estimates** (6–8% by 2025) that explicitly attribute the gap to Brexit and not mainly to other shocks.[2][14][1]
- **Declining belief among Leave voters that Brexit has strengthened Britain's ability to make laws**, paired with historically low trust in government.[13][12]

These threaten the closure that Brexit is both democratically justified and practically beneficial. If the economic drag appears long-term and the very constituencies who mandated Brexit feel it has not delivered control, the sovereign-restoration narrative risks looking hollow or self-defeating.

Leakage:

- The grammar occasionally borrows **efficiency and competitiveness language** from the Economic-Institutional grammar (e.g., "we must use our freedoms to boost growth") to defend Brexit on pragmatic grounds, not just democratic ones.[10][15]
- It also sometimes borrows **"left-behind towns" rhetoric** from the Class-Distributional grammar to argue that Brexit can be harnessed to regenerate neglected regions, implicitly conceding the importance of distributional concerns.[1][2]

These leakages show an implicit recognition that sovereignty alone cannot sustain legitimacy without economic performance and distributional responsiveness.

6.2 Economic-Institutional Integration

Threatening counter-signals:

- **Resilient headline trade figures and strong services export growth**, which can be used to argue that Brexit's economic damage is overstated.[6][15][10]
- **Relative political stability of the UK's territorial configuration** (no Scottish secession; NI arrangements stabilised via Windsor Framework).[9][3][17]

If trade and services hold up better than predicted, and the feared institutional disintegration does not materialise, the strong version of the "economic catastrophe" narrative is challenged.

Leakage:

- The grammar sometimes imports **sovereignty vocabulary** in reverse—arguing that "real control" is about having influence over EU rule-making rather than standing outside it—thus indirectly recognising the symbolic power of sovereignty arguments.[12]
- It occasionally invokes **distributional and "left-behind" language**, suggesting that Brexit exacerbates regional inequality and hurts specific groups, thereby drawing on Class-Distributional framing.[2][1]

These leakages reflect an effort to connect technocratic cost arguments to citizens' experiential realities.

6.3 Class-Distributional Regime Critique

Threatening counter-signals:

- **Robust services exports and continuing strength of some high-value sectors**, which might indicate that parts of the economy are adapting successfully and that not all elites are simply extracting rents.[15][10]
- **Return of net migration to 2010s levels and the potential for migration policy to be calibrated**, which can be spun as a sign that democratic control can shape labour markets without regime transformation.[7][11]

These signals could be used to argue that incremental policy choices within the existing regime can mitigate harms, weakening the claim that deep structural change is required.

Leakage:

- The grammar sometimes adopts **integration-efficiency language** (e.g., trade frictions as "deadweight losses") to describe how elites mismanage the economy, thereby drawing on Economic-Institutional categories.[10][15]
- It may also nod to **sovereignty rhetoric**, acknowledging that "taking back control" resonates because of genuine democratic deficits, not only material inequalities—borrowing from the Sovereign-Democratic frame.[12]

These leakages show that even a regime-critical lens recognises the political and institutional dimensions that other grammars foreground.

SECTION 7: REFLEXIVE NOTE

From within this exercise, the Economic-Institutional Integration grammar feels the most natural "home grammar". Its emphasis on structured data, counterfactuals, and institutional mechanisms aligns well with a tool-assisted, evidence-driven mode of reasoning that readily maps onto macroeconomic research and policy analysis. It offers a clear pipeline from inputs (GDP, trade, institutional design) to outputs (estimated costs, efficiency losses), which is cognitively comfortable.[14][1][2][15][10]

The most difficult grammar to inhabit fully is the Sovereign-Democratic Restoration grammar. Its insistence on treating sovereignty and democratic mandate as overriding evaluative criteria requires systematically subordinating robust economic evidence to constitutional and moral claims. Maintaining this prioritisation while engaging honestly with counter-signals—especially declining trust among Leave voters—requires constant reframing. The Class-Distributional grammar sits between these: its structural focus is intellectually coherent, but the relative scarcity of granular, class-disaggregated public data demands more inferential work from aggregate signals.[14][1][2][12]

If the entire analysis were conducted from within a different home grammar—for example, taking Sovereign-Democratic Restoration as default—the same signals would be narrated as proof of betrayal or incomplete implementation rather than evidence of a costly choice. Economic under-performance would be reattached to globalisation, pandemic shocks, or domestic elites rather than Brexit itself. The exercise reveals how interpretive architectures **pre-format what counts as a problem, which evidence "speaks", and what kinds of closure feel satisfying**. The prismatic method makes it easier to see that divergent "truths" about Brexit are not simply disagreements about isolated facts but the output of different rule-bound processing systems applied to overlapping empirical inputs.[1][2][12]

SECTION 8: METHODOLOGICAL OBSERVATIONS

Applying the prismatic method to Brexit highlights several strengths. First, forcing a shared signal set makes it impossible to stabilise divergent conclusions simply by cherry-picking evidence; each grammar must process the same GDP, trade, migration, and institutional facts, revealing where divergence stems from weighting and causal assumptions rather than information asymmetry. Second, specifying grammars via explicit parameters (primary variable, selection rules, closure) surfaces background commitments that usually remain implicit in public debate—such as whether sovereignty, efficiency, or equality is treated as foundational.[3][17][11][14][1][10]

Difficulties arise in practice. Distinguishing "signal selection rules" from "weighting priorities" can blur when a grammar both includes and systematically marginalises certain data (e.g., sovereignty grammar admitting GDP data but treating them as peripheral). Operationalising "admissible closure" also requires care: one must avoid caricaturing grammars while still articulating their internal logic and limits. Guidance on how to handle **time and counterfactuals** would help, especially for cases like Brexit where many key claims are about "what would have happened otherwise". More explicit instructions for incorporating distributional detail when disaggregated data are sparse would also support class-focused grammars.[2][14][1]

Refinements might include: (1) asking analysts to draw a simple "grammar matrix" early on, mapping each grammar's stance on a small set of core signals; (2) encouraging a brief "internal critique" where each grammar tries to repair itself against its most threatening counter-signals; and (3) adding a meta-step that explicitly compares **how each grammar treats counterfactual uncertainty**. Overall, the method is powerful for making interpretive divergence visible, but benefits from careful scaffolding in areas where empirics and modelling (e.g., macroeconomic estimates, migration projections) play a large role.

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